STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 20 · The Bed Is a Covenant

Transcript · Wes Hart

Good. Come on in. Find a chair. Uh, you don't have to earn it. I'm Wes. Glad you made it here. I put one word on a card so I would not dodge today. Bed. My boy saw it on the counter. He said, we getting a new one? Different subject. He let it go. Uh, I almost did. Last time we talked about laying a grip down. And about asking what she actually needs. Keep both. They still stand. Today we walk into the room a lot of decent men will not name. How many of you felt the air change when you saw where this was headed? Hands. I'm not writing them down. Yeah. That's fair. Stay anyway. Before we walk around it, here is the whole thing. The bed is a vow kept with a body. A contract has two ends. A covenant has all of you. This is— this is not a craft talk. If all you take is try harder, you will nod at me and go home the same man. Uh, some of you share a house. Some of you don't. Some of you did, and the quiet there is not funny. You stay. Honored by all means the whole room. Give us a mower that won't start and we become a shop class. Say the word bed and half of us inspect a shoe. Uh, I inspected that shoe. Uh, called it privacy. Uh, it was fear, with better manners. Some of you hoped I would talk around it. I won't. Uh, a man can carry this alone until he is tired and very good at the mask. The mask gets heavy. Uh, he calls it fine. Uh, we set it down. In this room. With brothers. You don't have to perform. You do have to be honest. No smirk in it. And no hiding. Here, with your brothers. You can hear a hard true thing and keep your seat.

These four marks are the sentence we keep coming back to. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard them in here. Uh, today they don't stay by the door. They come down the hall. Into the private hours, where nobody claps and nobody posts it. It is— it is the same man when the room gets small. Passivity, here, is going mute and calling the mute peace. You feel a distance. Uh, you tell yourself it settles. It doesn't settle. It sets. Responsibility is your eyes, your hurry, your distance, your silence. Uh, not a speech about what she owes. Some of you have been sinned against. Uh, I know that ache. Uh, the pain's real. It is still not a permission slip for a second life after dark. Courage is the talk you keep moving down the list. And the truth you put in a brother's hand Uh, before your mouth sands it. The real pay is not a secret that paid you for one night. God's pay. The Father sees the shut door. He is not embarrassed by a faithful hidden hour. He is not fooled by a clean face over a divided life. A man can be brave on the job and passive at his own table. Uh, he'll take the hard call. He will not answer his wife about this. Uh, that is not strength. That is courage that picked a favorite room. If you are young, or still single, there is no lobby where your body doesn't count yet. Passivity now will not become courage later. Hold the four while we talk. Reject the mute. Own what is yours. Go first. Want the reward that lasts.

Let me separate two words men mix up on purpose. A contract is built so you can leave clean if the other person fails. A covenant is built for staying. Uh, I rented a little place once. Some years back now. The kind part of that paper was the last page. I could already picture the morning I handed the keys back and walked off down the block. The landlord and I both kept an eye on whether the other had slipped. That is a contract. You trade a service. You watch the other party. You keep a copy in case you need it. I liked that paper. Uh, I knew the day it ended. Nothing in it asked for my whole life. You can stare at an end date and feel, you know, oddly settled. A vow will not hand you that. A covenant is a different posture. You hand over yourself. Not a shift. Not a mood, if the mood holds. You. The bed is where that promise either gets a body or gets contradicted by one. I kept— I kept a last page warm in my own head during a hard stretch. Uh, I never packed. Uh, I rehearsed how reasonable I'd sound if I were finished with the hard part. Uh, I called it wisdom. It was a man keeping his name off a promise he had already made. You can— you can be polite for years and still be half gone on the inside. She can feel a man who is present. She can feel a man who is renting. Right? The promise did not come with a cancellation line. A hard season does not void it. You don't get yourself back as a refund for decent behavior. Uh, here is the sentence again. The bed is a vow kept with a body. A contract has two ends. A covenant has all of you.

Now the page, before the arguments. Genesis two, verses twenty four and twenty five. That is why a man leaves his father and mother and is united to his wife, and they become one flesh. Adam and his wife were both naked, and they felt no shame. Stay with me. One flesh. Nothing hidden. No shame in it. Uh, and the One who made them called that good. The loud story around us calls this a hobby. Two adults. A free evening. No tomorrow owed. Then everybody goes home. Some of us learned the other story in a church voice, lowered, like you talk about a spill. It was something you got through and did not mention. A little bit wrong, even inside a marriage. Uh, I carried it longer than I'll admit. I could joke at almost anything. Uh, this one, I cleared my throat and found a new subject. Uh, both are lies. God made this before anything was broken. He was— He was not embarrassed by the man and the woman. He is still not. Hebrews thirteen, verse four. Marriage should be honored by all, and the marriage bed kept pure, for God will judge the adulterer and all the sexually immoral. Honored. Not snickered at. Not handled like a spill you hide. Kept pure does not mean grim, or rare, or a prize for looking impressive. It means kept for what it is, between the two people it belongs to, and treated as holy because He said so. He made it. He guards it. If you are not married, don't drift. Honored by all is your line. Uh, your body's already speaking about a promise you may not have made. Uh, we won't borrow the hobby. We will not borrow the embarrassment. We take Him at His word.

So what does keeping it look like once there is a bed. Exclusive. All the way in. Not the woman at work. Not a memory you keep warming up. Not a screen in the dark. Matthew five, verse twenty eight. Anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart. A husband can stay home and still be gone. I called— I called it nothing, in a stretch

I hate to name. Uh, my body was home. Uh, my attention had another address. I told myself it did not count. I had not walked through a wrong door. She did not have proof to set on the table. She had a husband who was somewhere else while he ate. That is a split promise. The Father had already named it. I had to catch up. Then generous. First Corinthians seven, verse four. The wife does not have authority over her own body but yields it to her husband. In the same way, the husband does not have authority over his own body but yields it to his wife. Uh, men love the first sentence. Uh, they go quiet on it. The second one turned an old world over. You are for her joy. Uh, getting yourself finished is the smaller aim. Ask how she is made. Ask what would bless her. Then believe her, even if the pace is not the one you brought. Uh, I've treated the end of a night like an errand Uh, so I'd sleep. Uh, she knew when I'd come to be with her. Uh, and when I'd come to be done. I mean, those are different nights. Rushing her takes the gift back while you act like you offered it. A patient kindness is the promise Uh, with your hands in it. Loyal in public, and selfish when the door shuts, is a story, not a vow.

I know the pleasant man who is already gone. I have been him in my own kitchen. Let me— let me tell you about another. I'll call him Curtis. He ran a small engine shop. One night after close we sat on two overturned buckets. Uh, the light hummed. He kept folding the same shop rag. He said his wife had started sleeping faced to the wall. Uh, he had it solved. She's tired. Uh, that's all of it. He could tell you when her car was due for oil. He could tell you the ball schedule without looking down. He could not tell me when he had last sat down only to hear her. He called the useful things being a family man. I asked when he had last put a hand on her shoulder that wasn't reaching past her. He folded the rag. He said he didn't watch that. A little later she said it at the sink. Calm. You are a good worker. I miss my husband. Uh, he listed the day. The shop. The boy. What he had carried. The list was true. Uh, he heard it while it was leaving his mouth. Uh, it sounded like a defense. He stopped. What he changed was small enough to sneer at if you want a grand repair. Phone in a drawer before supper. One question. He did not improve her answer. A hand on her shoulder while she rinsed a plate. He left it there. Uh, no plan behind it. He kept doing it. He told me the closeness came back. It started at that sink, not in the other room. He had been trying to fix the last room in the house. The promise had worn thin Uh, where lights were on. If your bed has gone quiet, Uh, don't use quiet to win. Don't make distance do your arguing. Uh, find what thinned. Uh, it usually started earlier, and it usually started bigger.

Uh, most of us never get a sentence out about any of this. Uh, we hint. We sigh. Then we are hurt that she did not translate it. I can explain a gutter like somebody assigned it. The honest question, uh, I would rather go check the gutters. Uh, she's watched me get handy right when a talk gets close. Handy is a good gift. It is a cheap place to hide. So if you are married, here is the keep. One gentle conversation. Honest. Not in the bed. Not in the bruise right after you have disappointed each other. I mean, in the daylight. Ask what she wants more of. Ask what she wants less of. Then get quiet long enough to actually hear it. How many of you are married, and

you cannot remember that talk, calm, away from the bed? Hands. No speeches attached. Yeah. You know why it's on the page. You don't wait until you feel ready. You do it because you already promised. And then the ordinary nearness. Uh, beds go quiet from neglect a long time before age does it. If your hand only arrives when you want the night to go somewhere, you are teaching her a meaning. She will believe you. A hand on her back in an ordinary evening, a kiss that is not a down payment, sitting close because you are glad she is in the room, that is the vow on an ordinary evening. Uh, I've been brave about trash. Uh, I've been a coward about that plain touch, the one with nothing clipped to it. Reject the distance. It feels like peace. It is a slow shut door. Lead with a calm ask in the light. Not with a speech in the dark when you are already mad. The bed will tell on what the rest of the house has been practicing.

Now the other bed. The one that fits in a pocket. It never has a hard day. It never needs you kind. It never asks you to stay after you are finished. Uh, that is why it beats a real woman on a tired night. A real woman can be hurt. A real woman can say not now. Uh, a picture says nothing but yes. Every time you go there, you practice a body that belongs to nobody. You also practice a lie. The lie says she is what is missing. What is missing is that you left. I have— I have gone there. Uh, looked steady in rooms like this. Lost hours I would not want quoted. I called it stress. Uh, I called it small. It was a small betrayal that knew the way back. The fight— the fight changed when it stopped being a rule I could shrink until it fit. It had her name. A living promise. Uh, a woman who trusted me with ordinary days. Uh, I can trim rules until my excuse survives. I cannot trim a wife. You know the difference, once you stop arguing with yourself. So the tools stay plain. One brother. The whole truth, not the tidied one. What it is. How often. Since when. Uh, a filter, and he holds the password. You don't. The phone charges in the kitchen, where morning can see it. Not in the dark by your head. That is you done waiting. You stop managing a secret and calling the management a win. That is responsibility. Your eyes. Your thumb. That is leading. The key goes in a hand that loves you and is not impressed. The reward you are after is God's. Not the cheap hit a lit screen pays when the house has gone still. Secrecy feeds it. Light starves it. Tell him before you clean the story up.

The promise does not change. Uh, the shape of keeping it does. When we brought a baby home, the nights went thin. She was spent. Healing. I started measuring the gap, like a man waiting on a part to land at the counter. That little measurement turned her healing into a test. She did not need a referee standing in the doorway. She needed— she needed a husband whose hands could be kind and want nothing back for a long stretch. When she was ready, the way back was slow. A question in it. Room to stop. The trust you keep while she is weak is the trust you stand on later. Sickness does not shelve what you promised. It changes the errand. Uh, bring the water. You sit. You stay when closeness will not look like it used to. Kindness that never goes further is still you keeping faith. In the middle of a life her body will do something it has not done before. Don't— don't call it rejection before she has said a word. Ask. Go with her. Be a man who can hear a change without building a case. And if you have some years on you, hear

this. Faithfulness can slow and still be sweet. If a day comes when that part of loving her cannot happen anymore, you did not stop being her husband. Learn what the bottles are for. Uh, sit where she can see you. Keep your word with a gentleness that has nowhere else to go. The room can be still. You are still hers. If the bed itself is hurt, pain, or an old harm that makes a touch feel unsafe. Uh, don't grit your teeth at a page and name that faith. A doctor. A pastor. Uh, a man who can hear it and stay. Go slow. An empty side of a bed is not a joke in this room.

Uh, some aren't in a marriage bed. Stay put. How many of you figured this hour was for husbands? Hands up. I want to see them. Yeah. This hour has your name on it. If you are single and you hope to marry, uh, your body is already casting a vote. You are building a covenant. Or you are spending one that does not exist yet. First Thessalonians four. Learn to control your own body in a way that is holy and honorable. Learn means practice, not a mood you wait on. If you stay nearly promised and never actually vow, careful men slip right there. A shut door is a poor chaperone. Don't call that nerve. When your life can hold a wife, and she is the one, ask her. If you are single again, single again is still single. Uh, a first marriage did not hand you a softer law. I'll call him Doyle. He moved a woman into the house and told the crew at work that the lonely part was handled. His girl set her bag down. Saw the extra coat. Asked him plain. Does she live here. Are you married. Uh, he laughed it off right there. He had told that girl, for years, that a promise is a real thing. He asked the woman to leave. The house went quiet. He told me the quiet was cleaner Uh, than what he'd nearly taught. Your kids learn what a man does when he is lonely. No shared address dressed up as a vow. Same brother. Same filter. Same phone where morning can see it. If she has died, I will not joke about that long quiet. He is not asking you to pretend the house feels full. Uh, keep yourself clean. Uh, he didn't forget those years. He is near through these years.

Paul puts the one-flesh line down, then he says a strange thing. Ephesians five, verse thirty one. For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh. This is a profound mystery. Uh, he is talking about Christ and the church. So your bed is saying something about somebody, even if you never meant to. Uh, she learns it from your body, not from a speech you meant well. A wife is not only learning you. She is catching a glimpse of whether real love stays when it costs a man something. When a man is only hers, when he stays, when he is patient, when he will not punish her with silence or with pressure, she gets a small true look at a love that does not quit. Faithful on purpose. Glad she is his. In it for good. Break that with your body or with your eyes, and you lie about how Christ loves His people. That weighs more than a private embarrassment. It is also why coming back matters. A lot of good men have failed right here and told no one. If that is you, don't polish it on the way to the table. First John one, verse nine. If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness. Uh, say it to God for real. Say it to a brother who will not sand it down. Uh, hidden shame keeps its job. Spoken shame can be forgiven and set down. You can start again today. Not when you feel stainless. Begin again

today. He is not holding out for a man who never missed. He meets the man who tells the truth and keeps the promise again.

Let me land this, and then the tables are yours. The bed is a vow kept with a body. A contract has two ends. A covenant has all of you. Uh, hope you leave with the thin place named, if there is one, and one clear way you will keep the vow. Not a louder effort. A truer one. Your workbook is open for this. Take the questions the way I say them. Where is the crack, if there is one? Have you been building, or have you been spending? What will you keep. The conversation, the filter, or the phone on the kitchen charger. Name it. On the page. Out loud to God Uh, while you're still here. Eyes. A screen. Hurry. A grudge you feed when nobody is looking. A silence. A long neglect. Or say it plain. Building. Or spending. Uh, then the keep. If you are married, Uh, one honest conversation about the bed. Not in the bed. Ask what she wants more of. Ask what she wants less of. Uh, hear it all. If you are single, or single again, get the filter in place. Uh, let him hold the password. Charge the phone in the kitchen. Tell a brother the crack. If it is the screen, tell him all of it. What. How often. Since when. Uh, don't shave it down. Let him keep that password. Uh, if he's at your table, begin with him. If you came by yourself, you still owe one man the truth. Write his name before you get up. Carry this line, and write it once. The bed is a vow kept with a body. A contract has two ends. A covenant has all of you. That is the work in front of you. Uh, open this part of the workbook. Do it together. Name the crack. Name the keep. Uh, a man who says it here can say it at home. Go on.